



BLADE RUNNER 2049 - ANALYZED CINEMA - PART THREE

Welcome back everyone! I hope everyone is doing well and learning tons from the Canon of Design content. I really appreciate everyones support, thank you so much!

Today we have the third and final entry for our [Blade Runner 2049](#) series. We've already covered tons of **techniques** and tips for **composition** and design. We even mentioned areas to avoid while composing. Now, we'll analyze tons of beautiful visuals from the trailer to the **dynamic symmetry** grid and other design techniques. We'll even look at sequences and briefly talk about color. Let's do this!

Official Trailer

I'm sure you've seen the trailer by now, but here it is for quick reference. I mention the way certain scenes incorporate movement, so you can refer to this if needed.

[BLADE RUNNER 2049 Trailer - For Educational Purposes Only](#)

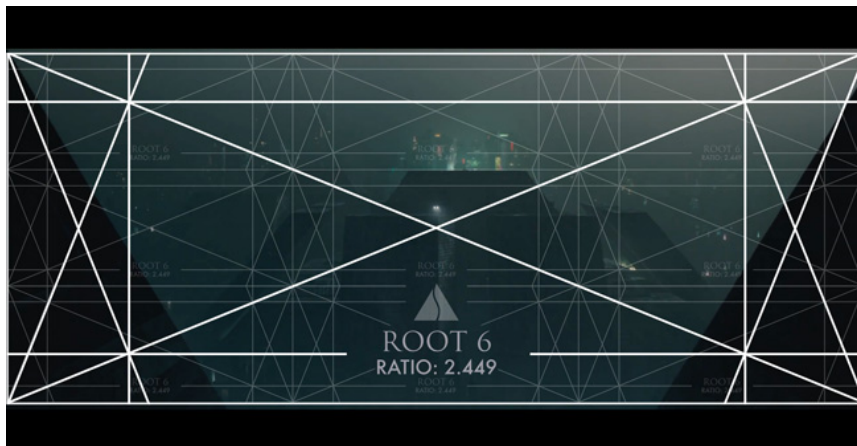
Analyzing the Amazing Scenes of the Trailer

Ok, finally, the part you've been waiting for! Let's check out the other scenes and see why they work so well.

In this **establishing shot** (see [Day 267](#)) we see **aerial perspective** (see [Day 42](#)) and some nice diagonals coming down from the sides.



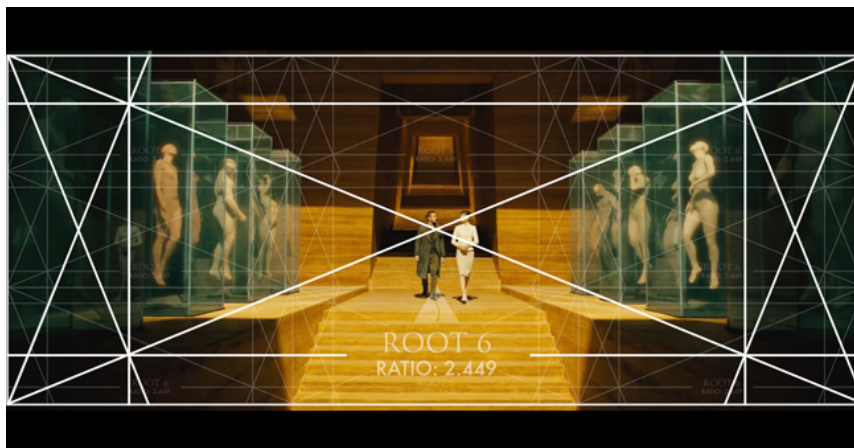
We don't need the root 6 on top of this scene to understand why it works, but here you go. It's good to start seeing the visuals in this way because it helps us break down things further. I love all of the center compositions they use because it's always taught as something to avoid, but the **Law of Symmetry** (see [Day 57](#)) is a beautiful thing when it's combined with other design techniques.



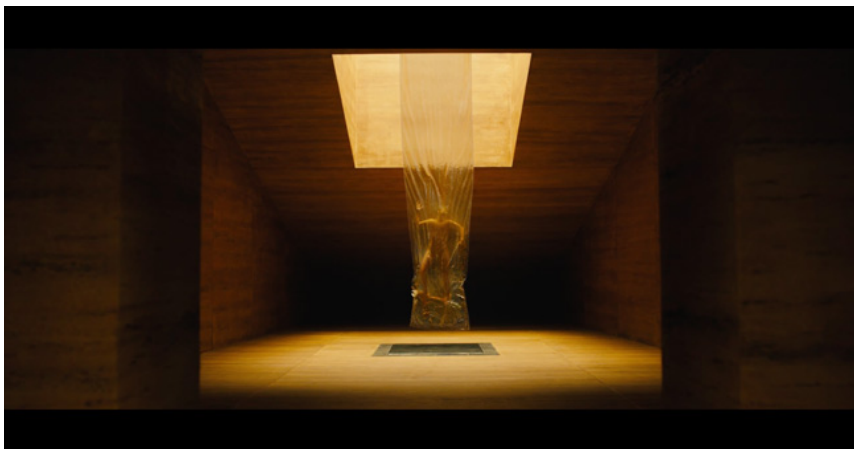
Speaking of the Law of Symmetry, check out this next scene. Pretty stunning, and in the trailer you can see the shaft of light go from background to foreground.



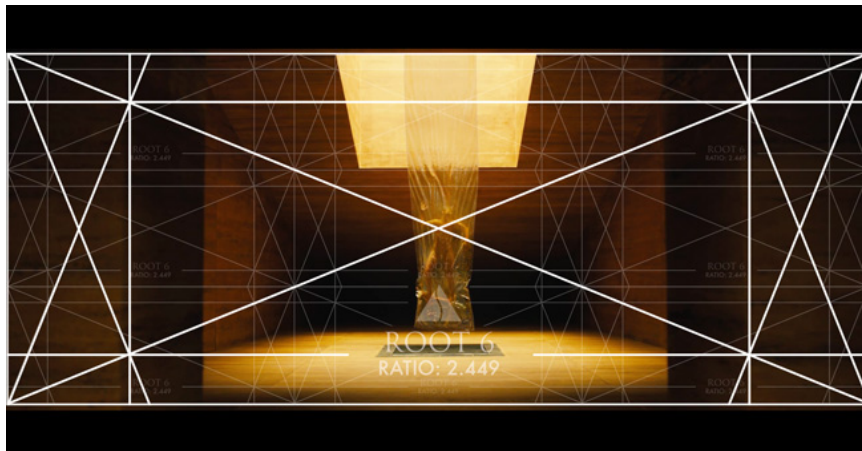
When we line it up to our grid we can see the placement of their subjects and the surroundings. Strong diagonals are used and some parallel the major diagonals and reciprocals.



Another use of the Law of Symmetry with this abstract concept.



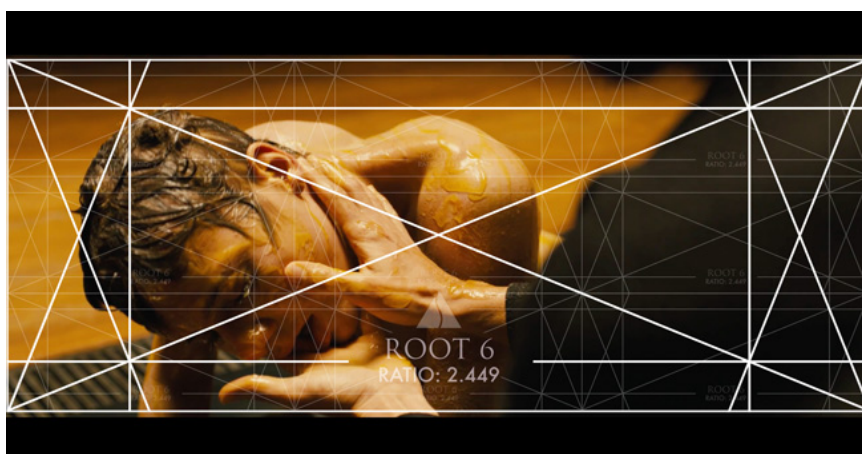
We can see the structure locking in on the left, the square piece on the floor, and the sky light. No diagonals, but nice symmetry and visual.



Here is the dude that was born from the plastic sack above. Slimy and covered in synthetic birth juices. Eww!



Notice how the head and hand both fall on the sinister diagonal. The eyes parallel the reciprocal, the back locks into the top horizontal, and the left arm locks into the phi vertical.



Some really nice aerial perspective going on here....one of the main techniques used in cinema to create depth, mystery, and separation from the background.



We can see the strong diagonals and the placement of the character and background elements. No **brownie points** for the placement of this subject...sorry.



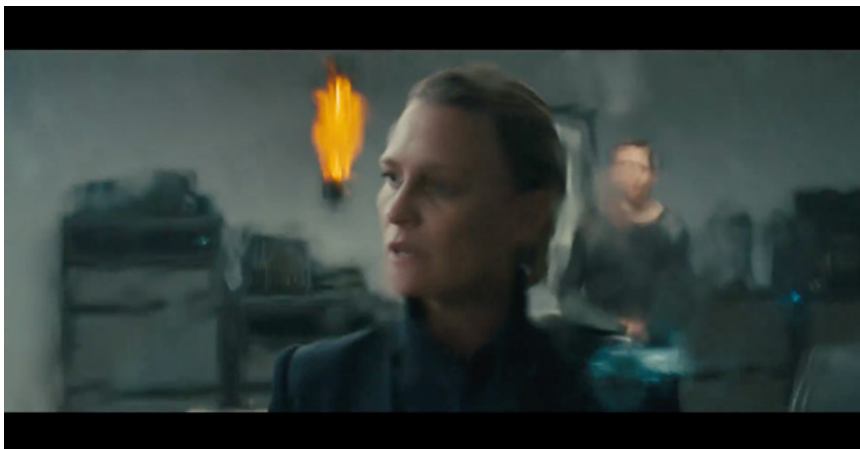
Another sweet establishing shot. As the visual artist creates this scene in the computer, they could have the small ship parallel a the baroque diagonal.



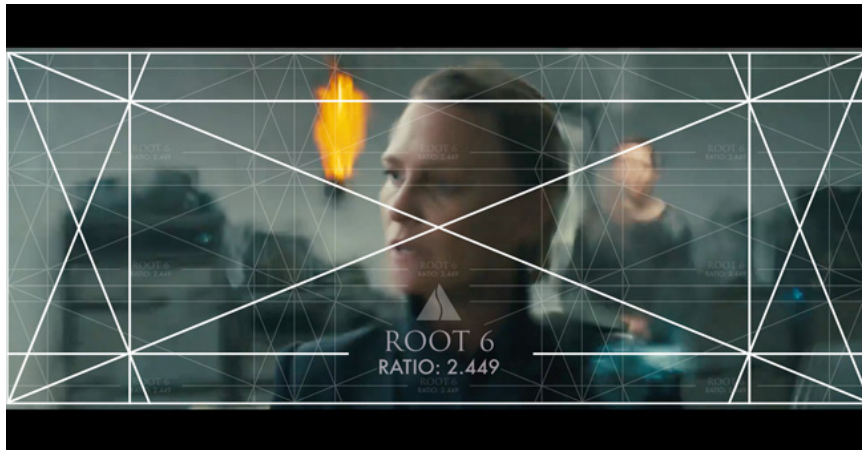
We can see how the lit area on the lower left and right of the structure parallels the sinister diagonal. The right side locks into the vertical as well.



This is a really cool scene where there is water or rain dripping down the window and they shoot through it.



Notice the center placement of the main subject, her gazing direction, and the position of the orange light and background character.



This is called the "[Kubrick stare](#)" because Stanley Kubrick is known to repeat this look in most of his movies.



I love how they don't incorporate the rule of thirds from left to right when placing the head of their subject. They compose the shot off center, then balance it with the gazing direction. The eyes and lips fall on the phi horizontal.



Classic centered shot of the subject walking the busy streets with plenty of aerial perspective and diagonals. Speaking of **Kubrick**, he used one point perspective extensively (see [Day 260](#)).



Here we can see how the subject fits into the scene.



The right and left edge of his head lands on the 45 degree angle of the rebated square. The more you work with these grids, the less you'll have to double check the alignment. The square

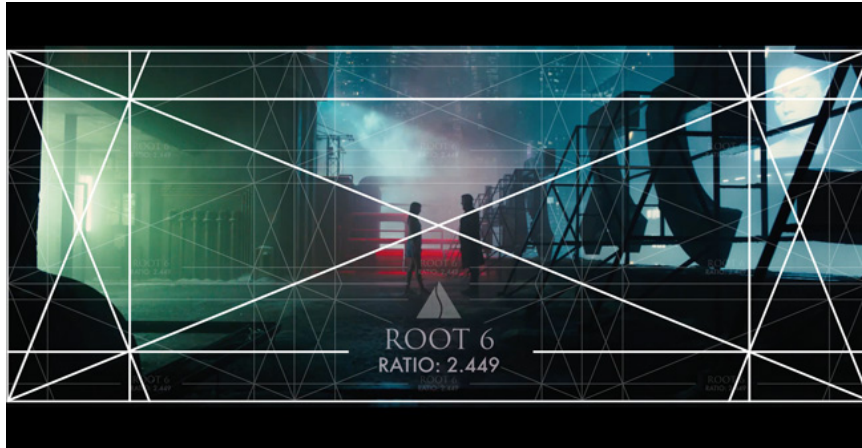
is the easiest geometric shape to find...ok, the triangle is pretty easy to find too. These shapes are best when hidden, or created by using the **Gestalt Psychology** techniques.



Wow, look at the light design and composition here! Center composition again, but many diagonals, aerial perspective, **figure-ground relationship** (see [Day 21](#)), and stunning light. They are even playing with the **colors** red, green, and blue...only missing yellow to complete my perfect color palette (see [#370](#)).



Here we can see the center placement of the subjects, the diagonals, the background visual on the right, and the light on the left.



More aerial perspective helping separate the subjects from the background. We also see **aspective view** (see [Day 78](#)), which helps us identify them easier in a **silhouetted** scenario.



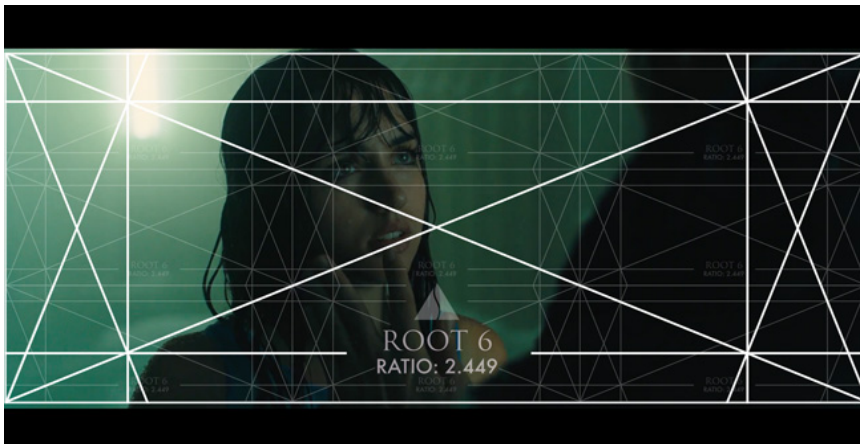
The subjects are locked in, and the arm is on the sinister diagonal. The structure on the right side parallels the reciprocal.



Here's another shot where the position the subject off center instead of on a third as many of us are taught in school and online.



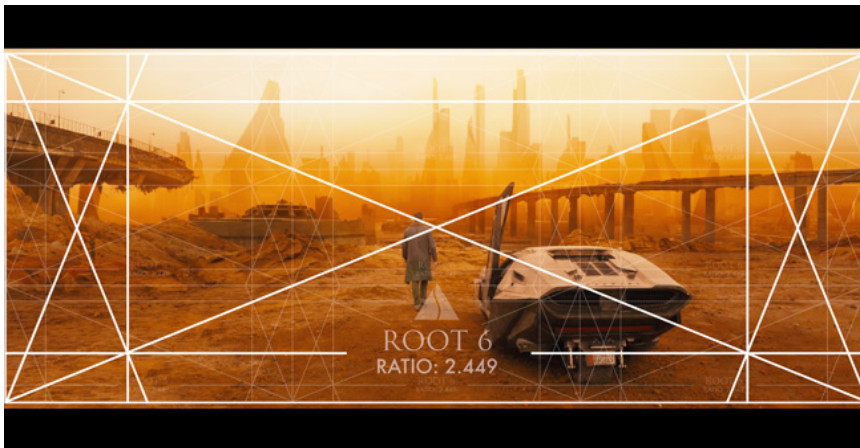
The light on the left is locked into the **polar point** (see [Day 5](#)), her eyes locked into the horizontal, her left shoulder is locked into the diagonal and vertical, and the subject on the right parallels the reciprocal.



Wow, look at this freakin' scene! Center composition, but offset and balanced with the car and the structure on the left. Lots of depth and aerial perspective too!



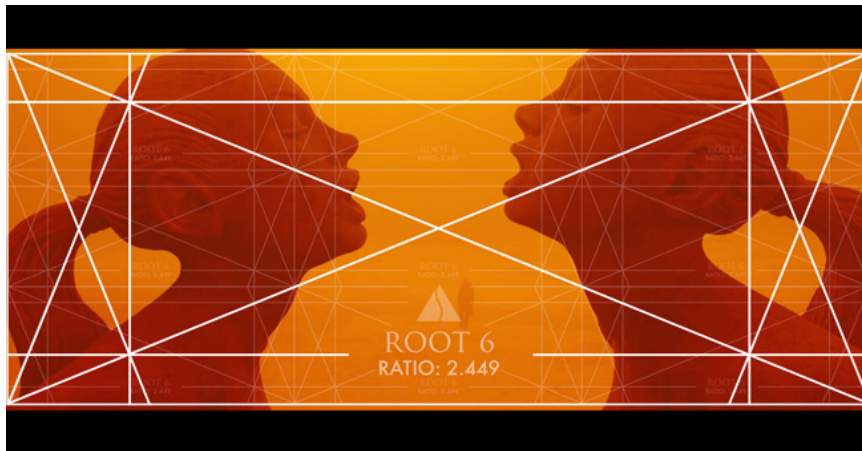
The bridge looking structure is on the phi horizontal, and the the door of the car falls on the square edge.



Such a cool visual! Aerial perspective, FGR, aspective view...so good!



The statue parallels the diagonals of our root 6 on the right, and the chin on the left.



Such great atmosphere and depth in this part of the trailer.



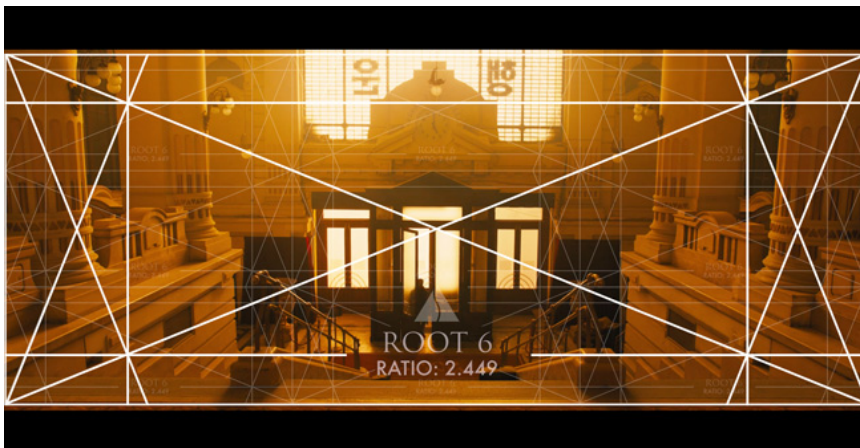
Check out the placement of the character on the left vertical. Brownie points for this scene!



This reminds me of The Met museum in NYC. Center composition, diagonals, and aerial perspective and atmosphere created with the glow of light coming from the upper windows.



Here we can see how the structure lines up to the grid. Many verticals and horizontals lining up.



In these next couple of shots, I wanted to point out the way they **reveal** the character. They start from the shadow and have him move into the light.



This is a technique they use in many movies, but the one that comes to mind is "[The Departed](#)" when they introduce Jack Nicholson for the first time.



Notice how the subject is off center right and looking left.



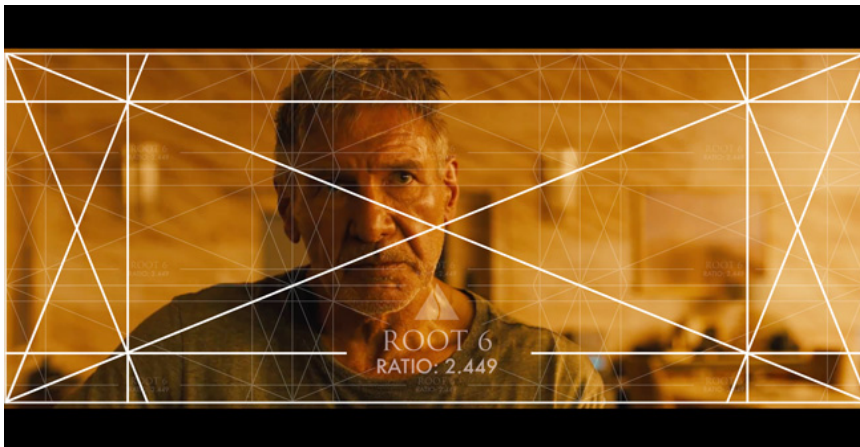
Great balance and not placed on the third. His head tilt is paralleling the reciprocal and the background structure locks into the vertical.



Another example of off center head placement.



Now, all we need to do to get brownie points is get those eyes out of the red zone and perhaps place them on a diagonal, or the phi horizontal. The background elements lock into the grid as well.



Here's a couple of fly-by, center compositions with juicy aerial perspective.



And another...



I love this reflection shot from the car window. It adds depth, context, and a nice diagonal.



We can see how the diagonal of the finger parallels the baroque, and in the moving sequence it eventually locks into the baroque.



I love the lighting, FGR, and aspective view in this shot. With her arms separated a bit, we are able to interpret the shape more clearly.



The lighting near the silhouette parallels the reciprocal, and locks into the upper horizontal. The platform parallels the baroque diagonal.



This is a cool shot with aerial perspective, aspective view, and a mixture of warm and cool colors. Not much to line up to our grid because the information is minimal.



These next couple of screen shots are just showing their sequencing. Different views of the explosion to make it more action packed and interesting for the viewer.



Here's the other shot directly from behind.



Do you see the triangle of light? Do you see the aspective view? You're starting to see the design of this exciting movie trailer.



We can see how the lights are almost locking into the major diagonals.



Nice back lighting and triangular light shapes.



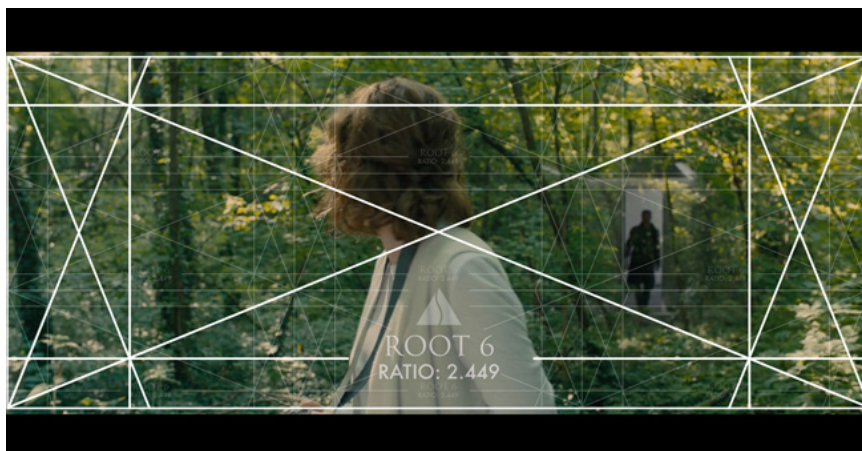
Here we can see that the diagonals of light are almost locking in again. The subject is off left center, and his gazing direction is to the right.



This composition is nice and plays with the gazing direction. She is off center left, and gazing right towards the subject....but she is twisting opposite of what we are use to seeing, which hides her face.



We can see the positioning of the background door, and the tree near the door locks into the reciprocal.



I saved the best scene for last. Look at this composition! We've got FGR, aspective view, aerial perspective, and lots of eye candy.



We can see that the diagonal of smoke locks into the sinister diagonal, the tree locks into the right vertical and many branches parallel the baroque diagonal. The car locks into the lower horizontal.



Conclusion

When we combine multiple techniques in one scene we get stunning results. Adding movement to the scene can adhere to the grid as well, so try this next time you are directing an actor or floating a space ship across the screen.

Thanks again for joining in for this article series. As always, thanks for everything and all of the support! Be sure to share these techniques with your artistic friends. See you next time!